



The newly-inaugurated Panerai Boutique at Jio World Plaza in Mumbai (top); and Panerai CEO Jean-Marc Pontroué

it's not the same business. It can have some influence on what we do for sure. Because you have only two wrists, you cannot wear hundreds of watches. I'm a big fan of it because it has been a disruptor in our industry. It has led the new generation to realise that wearing watches could be a good way to get information about your health, performance, news, etc. But that is a functional business, while ours is an aspirational business. Panerai is about passing on your watch to your kids. It's an investment. A

smartwatch lasts for two or three years and is then replaced. It's a consumable, one that you use and throw. We are not in that business.



Do you feel that watches are still a sound investment?

We have 28 models with retail price higher than the original price. We developed a model for a charity auction where the estimated price was between 60,000 and 180,000 Swiss francs but was bought by a Taiwanese collector

for 355,000 Swiss francs. For us, it was important because it shows the desirability of the brand.



Panerai has been traditionally about men's watches but now there are a lot of unisex watches. Will we have a specific range for women?

Men remain 75-80% of our customers, but we now see a growing number of women wearing big watches. The 38 mm dial in different colours and with coloured straps is a growing point of interest.

Over the last few years, an increasing number of women are buying our watches, even though the brand is extremely 'masculine'. We don't want to change the positioning and the messaging of the brand. We will not make diamond watches. I know India is a big market for stone watches. But we won't do so.



Nearly all global luxury watch brands happen to be European. Would you expect any new watch brand to come up from any other parts of the world?

You know, I never say never, ever. Nobody would have expected that disruption would come from the US when it came to smartwatches. So, you never are protected from being sure that everything will continue to come from Switzerland.

By the way, only 3% of watches come from Switzerland. 97% are of non-Swiss origin. The value is, however, 80% Swiss. Customers buy a slice of history. They have been buying our storytelling since the 1860s. It's very hard to be taken seriously in the higher-end watch segment if you don't have at least 100 years, 200 years, or 300 years of history. And that's what is perhaps protecting our business from new arrivals compared to other fashion accessories. **BT**

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